

worked a little on a command line tool called ‘csv2db’, that allows you to load CSV data into a database. I see these projects as a chance to educate myself. You read something, and then you try to implement it and see whether you really understood it, whether it works and so on.

**Q. How did this change happen from being a developer to a product manager?**

**A.** My path was probably highly irregular. I am from Austria originally where I worked as a developer for an American company headquartered in New York. I was part of the performance engineering team. I was actually one of those guys who tried to profile the code and those skills eventually brought me to troubleshoot production systems at customer sites. I relocated to New York, and then a couple of years later Oracle asked me to join their pre-sales team as a result of our earlier interactions in running proof-of-concepts and performance tests on their systems together.

I liked the opportunity to learn by interacting with customers directly and discussing requirements. But for me, the turning point was moving back into development and specifically into the technical aspects as product manager.

**Q. What are the top two ‘must have’ qualities of your role?**

**A.** I think one must definitely be able to accept ever-changing requirements. But it’s not just a reactive job. You also have to have a curious mindset. If you have a curious mind, are open to new ideas, and can think out-of-the-box, you can establish your priorities and grow into the role.

**Q. What would you like to say about the challenges in your current role?**

**A.** Product manager is a very diverse and ever-changing role. One must be highly adaptive because

you need to go through steering the product, prioritising the internal roadmap and also accept changes depending on market demands and customer needs. So the key challenge, and also the fun part, is that no day really ever looks the same.

**Q. Any important risk you have taken so far which you think might inspire others?**

**A.** I think my shifting into product management was the biggest risk. The future is unpredictable and one must dare to take such risks. For open source projects, it’s probably taking the step and actually wanting to contribute to a project. It can be a bit daunting in the beginning, especially to know where to start contributing for very popular active projects. Not all contributions have to be done in code; often people appreciate help with the documentation or testing. There are many ways to get started — the important thing is that you do get started. If you are passionate about something, you will have to go after it. You may have people not reacting the way you expect at first, but that’s okay. It will essentially help to learn.

**Q. What do you consider as top leadership qualities?**

**A.** There are a couple of things that I think are important for leadership. And the first one is that it’s okay to be wrong and acknowledge it. This also encourages people around you to freely share ideas. The other thing would be to take chances and get out of your comfort zone. I have never formally learnt product management. I just was intrigued by it, gave it a try and I thought, let’s see how it goes. It has put me in a good space for growth.

**Q. Anything you are not very happy about when it comes to open source?**

**A.** I wish the industry would not follow this ever increasing hype

cycle for new stuff. New doesn’t automatically mean great. We may talk just about all the new things out there, but the world still runs on Linux and, remember, we still use the HTTP, TCP/IP and all those technologies today. The fundamental technologies that connect us around the globe have been there for a long time. Something doesn’t have to be new to be great and often new technologies go just as fast as they came.

**Q. What are the major risks in going ahead with new technologies?**

**A.** A major risk is forgetting or not wanting to ask the “why” we need the new technology. In our industry we get excited very quickly about something that we then want to work with. Sometimes that means that we oversimplify some business requirements and kind of omit the downsides of a new technology, just so that we can use it for a new project. I agree that new things lead to innovations and there is nothing wrong with that. But I have equally seen just as many projects fail that tried to replace the legacy system because a new buzz technology is out there and looks attractive. I’ve seen a three or four year-long project fail because no one bothered to look at the ‘why’ when replacing the previous system; and although it solved the new requirements, people forgot to ask themselves what the old system did well and they just ended up with those old issues again.

**Q. How does one keep away from the hype around new technologies?**

**A.** I would say that, as a developer, don’t just blindly follow the latest and greatest. If someone is telling you new stuff, well it’s great to know. But it’s no surprise to me that Linux runs the world and HTTP runs the Web, because those technologies are really well-designed.